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Thou Hast Made Me and Unmade Me:
Anxiety and Violence in Donne's Holy Sonnets

"Why… didn't you make me good enough…
so that you could have loved me?"
— Stephen Adly Guirgis
The Last Days of Judas Iscariot
(106)

John Donne's sonnets explore the relationship of humanity, sin, and redemption as mediated by the overarching power of God, who is simultaneously punishing and forgiving. In this essay, I argue that Donne sense and unravels God as an imposing authority who commits injustices against His own creations, but ultimately God's manipulation is so ingrained that Donne himself gives in to these impositions to seek salvation within God Himself.

Preordained Negligence

Donne's collection of 'Holy Sonnets' are characterised by the struggle of a Christian sinner, commonly accepted as the voice of Donne himself, who is approaching Death and trying to find redemption. Embroiled within this struggle, across several sonnets, he confronts the nature of the inherent sin of humanity, written onto us by virtue of simply being human. The Christian doctrine preaches this sort of *predeterminism*: Jesus, the son of God, died for the sins of humanity, including those they have not committed yet. The implication, of course, is that human beings in the future – despite the wishes of God and the teachings of Jesus – will commit sins that they need to be thus redeemed for. We are damned to hell before we were even born: the natural state of being a human is to be a sinner, and we are all relying on God's mercy to be free of sin.

Donne grapples with the paradox of humanity's sinfulness that contrasts with the supposedly loving and forgiving God that created it. In the very opening of the first of his 'Holy Sonnets', he asserts that God "hast made me" a human and a sinner, and demands that He "repair [him] now"

before he dies (sonnet 1, lines 1-2). These lines set the stage for the rest of his sonnets, particularly sonnet 2, which continue to confront the negligence (and sometimes outright cruelty) of God in refusing to take responsibility for his own sinful creations. In sonnet 2, this complex weave of the relationship between God and humanity makes itself more apparent: Donne lists out the reasons due to which he is beholden to God. First, he asserts once again that it is God who has made him; second, it was the blood of God's son, Jesus, that has "bought" (line 4) the purification of humanity's sin through crucifixion; and third, that he, like all other humans, is "[God's] servant…Thy sheep, Thine image" (line 7) who has betrayed him by committing sin. These are all given as evidence that humanity belongs to God, yet within these lines lurks a resentment – this "debt" (sonnet 9, line 13) that humanity owes to God has been imposed upon humans from God Himself.

Further, despite creating not only humanity but also his ownership over humanity, God does not "for [His] own work fight" (sonnet 2, line 11). In essence, Donne asks why God subjects his supposedly beloved creations to Hell, if he is the one who made them? He demands why God, as his creator and rightful owner, "wilt not choose [him]" (sonnet 2, line 13) but instead, He passively allows the Devil to "usurp", "steal" and "ravish" humanity by tempting them to sin (lines 9-10). Interestingly, the use of these words betrays Donne's implicit acceptance of the will of God – he relegates himself as an object that can be possessed and laid claim upon. He even symbolizes humanity's tendency to sin as a "betroth[al] unto your enemy" (sonnet 14, line 10), compounding the image of God as the neglectful father who willingly gives up his child to marry into another family – in other words, God rejects his own children and forces them into the property of another whose temptation to sin they cannot resist (sonnet 1, line 12).

He goes on to question why this sin is written onto the human condition by God in sonnet 9. He asks why "sins, else equal, in me more heinous" (line 6) than those of the apple and snake that condemned Adam and Eve. He speculates that it is just because of the "intent or reason, born in [us]" (line 5), but the paradox that the reader comes upon again is that this intent and reason was given to humanity by God himself. Nor does this ability to reason "defend but is captived, and proves weak or untrue" in the face of sin (sonnet 14, lines 7-8). So, Donne asks why God gave us these mental faculties just to punish us for and because of them?

However, Donne also accepts that, despite all these injustices, God is superior and will punish the sonneteer for his sins. In fact, if the Devil is the villain that has his clutches on Donne, it is only "when towards Thee / By Thy leave I can look, I rise again" (sonnet 1, lines 9-10) and "Thy grace [that] may wing me to prevent his art / And like an adamant draw mine iron heart" (lines 13-14). This attitude implies that humanity, if intrinsically sinful, is also intrinsically drawn to God (and only God) as a means of salvation. As he admits in a later poem, God has "enthrall[ed] me" in such a way that "[I] never shall be free" (sonnet 14, line 13). In other words, God has left no other path to humanity's redemption other than Himself. Now, what we must contend with is gaining this way of salvation with the knowledge that it was Him who created humanity and declared us sinful in the first place.

Stripping Individuality

So far, I have reconstructed Donne's unraveling of the cruel paradoxes that God's impositions lay on humanity, and Donne's accepting attitude towards this predetermined damnation. This acceptance most strongly manifests at the volta of his sonnets, where he gives in to this fate by pleading with God to remove this human sin from him. He subsumes himself in the structure of Christian faith, surrenders his demanding questions with a rhetorical one instead: "But who am I, that dare dispute with Thee?" (sonnet 9, line 9). Stachniewski (as found in Lim 6) proposes that this surrender requires the sonneteer "to obliterate the claims of self […]. The will had to be crushed before it would be, or while it was being, taken over by God." Essentially, Donne slips along the line of symbolic reason: being human is sinful, therefore being free of sin means no longer being a human.

Thus, to be redeemed we must transform into something that is not human: when we "leave the world, the flesh, the devil", we are "purged of evil" (sonnet 6, lines 13-14). To Donne, as I have discussed, redemption is only possible through God, then the only way to relinquish our humanity is through transforming ourselves at the hands of God. Indeed, the image of redemption is often portrayed as a transformation in the sonnets. In sonnet 4, humanity's soul, which is black with sin, can only be redeemed when one "make[s] thyself with holy mourning black" (line 10); the red of our remorseful and guilty "blushing" must become "Christ's blood […] That being red, it dyes red souls to white" (lines 12-14). In sonnet 9, he begs God, "of Thine only worthy blood / And my tears, make a heavenly Lethean flood / And drown in it my sin's black memory" (lines 10-12).

This transformation that Donne seeks characteristically takes the form of a spilling of blood, which in itself is a complex nexus of metaphorical redemption. First, blood is a symbol of human mortality, and its loss is the loss of mortality that is plagued with sin. Second, the spilling of blood is often a consequence of violence: it elicits a pain in the process of redemption, and this pain must be willingly borne by the sinner as Christ bore it for humanity (sonnet 11, line 10) – in other words, redemption is not truly redemption unless the sinner accepts both the suffering of being a sinful human and of the process of redemption. Lastly, the nature of this suffering at the hands of God involves an overwhelming loss of control – the "might" of Christ's blood in sonnet 4 and the "flood" in sonnet 9 overpower and subject the sinner to something he cannot control. It is, then, this loss of control that is the loss of humanity, which is what Donne strives to. And, indeed, it is this complete surrender to God that dispels the injustice of predeterminism.

Conclusion

In this paper, I have argued that Donne is a self-aware Christian: he acknowledges the contradictions in the doctrine of God who created humanity, only to deem humans as sinners for the ability of reason that He granted them, and yet make no protection for His own creations against the Devil. To compound this injustice, He offers only one way of redemption for humanity's sin: to completely eschew the humanity – that He created – through suffering and wholly accepting Him. Donne, too, is eventually subjected to this doctrine: he ceases his questioning of God to instead beg God to take away his human ability to reason and hence redeem him.

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References

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